

Chamomilla recutita syn. *Matricaria recutita* (Asteraceae)

German Chamomile

German chamomile's aromatic, slightly bitter taste, reminiscent of apples, is familiar to herbal tea drinkers. The herb's varied medicinal uses, however, are not as well known. It is an excellent herb for many digestive disorders and for nervous tension and irritability. Externally, it is used for sore skin and eczema. Roman chamomile (*Chamaemelum nobile*, p. 187) is a close relation, used in a similar way.



German chamomile is a useful herb to cultivate for home use.

Habitat & Cultivation

German chamomile grows in much of Europe and other temperate regions. The seeds are sown in spring or autumn and the flower heads are picked in full bloom, in summer.

Key Constituents

- Volatile oil (proazulenes, farnesine, alpha-bisabolol, spiroether)
- Flavonoids
- Bitter glycosides (anthemic acid)
- Coumarins

Key Actions

- Anti-inflammatory
- Antiallergenic
- Antispasmodic
- Relaxant
- Carminative

Research

■ **Trials in Germany** A cream made from German chamomile was tested in 1987 for its ability to heal wounds. The results produced were very positive. In 1993, another trial using German chamomile and four other herbs showed them to be most effective at easing infantile colic.

■ Premenstrual syndrome

An Iranian clinical trial compared chamomile with mefenamic acid for relief of premenstrual syndrome symptoms. Both were found effective in relieving the physical symptoms of premenstrual syndrome, but chamomile proved better in relieving emotional symptoms.

Traditional & Current Uses

■ **Digestive problems** German chamomile has been taken for digestive problems since at least the 1st century CE. Gentle and efficacious, it is very suitable for children. The herb is valuable for pain, indigestion, acidity, gastritis, gas, bloating, and colic. It is also used for hiatal hernia, peptic ulcer, Crohn's disease, and irritable bowel syndrome.

■ **Relaxation** German chamomile, which contains spiroether, a strong antispasmodic, eases tense muscles and period pain. It is known that women in ancient Rome commonly took chamomile to relieve menstrual cramps. Chamomile flowers also reduce irritability and promote sleep—especially helpful for children.

■ **Irritation** The herb is useful for hay fever and asthma. On steam distillation, the proazulenes produce chamazulene, which is markedly antiallergenic. Externally, it can be applied to sore, itchy skin, sore nipples, and eczema. It also relieves eyestrain. A poultice can be applied to sore breasts.

Self-help Uses

- Bites & stings, p. 303.

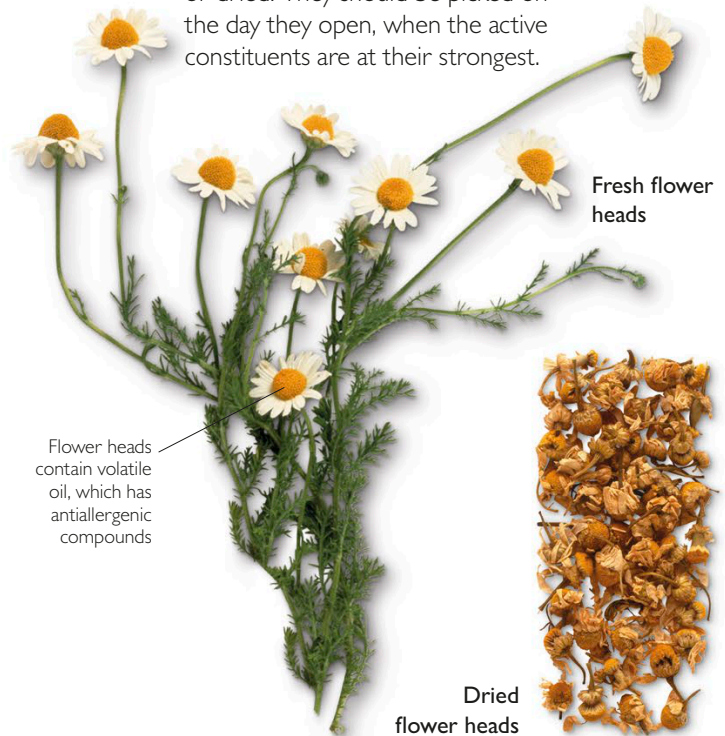


German chamomile

A sweetly aromatic annual growing to 2 ft (60 cm), with finely cut leaves and white flower heads.

Parts Used

Flower heads may be used fresh or dried. They should be picked on the day they open, when the active constituents are at their strongest.



Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** The fresh plant can cause dermatitis. Do not take the essential oil internally except under professional supervision. Take only on professional advice if using blood-thinning medication. Do not use the oil externally during pregnancy.



Cream (to make, p. 296). Rub on to sore or itchy skin.

Essential oil For diaper rash, combine 5 drops with 1 tbsp carrier oil and apply.



Making infusion with flower heads (see p. 291). For a good night's sleep, drink $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) before bed.



Infusion To relax irritable and overtired children, infuse 4 tsp dried herb in 2 cups (500 ml) water (see p. 291) and strain into a bath.



Ointment (to make, p. 295). Rub onto sore or inflamed skin.



Tincture (to make, p. 292). For irritable bowel syndrome, take 1 tsp diluted with $\frac{1}{2}$ cup (100 ml) water 3 times a day.

- Congestion & hay fever, p. 312.
- Colic, p. 318.
- Eczema, p. 300.
- Indigestion, p. 307.
- Insomnia, p. 309.

- Mild asthma, p. 301.
- Morning sickness, p. 317.
- Sore & tired eyes, p. 310.
- Sore nipples, p. 315.
- Stomach spasm, p. 305.